

NORTH AUSTRALIA SAVANNAS

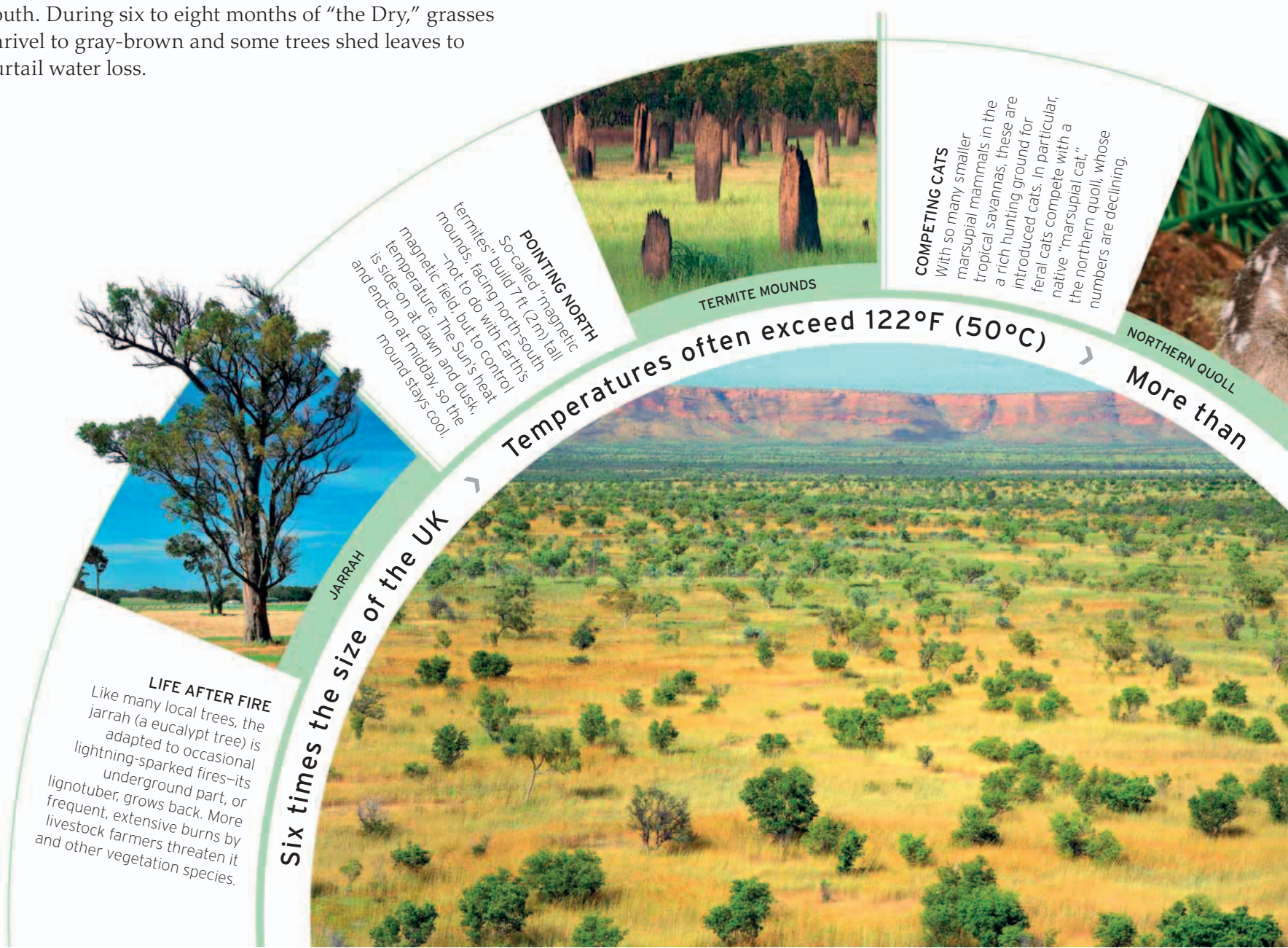
Unique tropical grasslands where insects rule

In most regions, grasslands tend to be dominated by a few species of grasses and large grazing mammals. In Australia's tropical north, these savannas stretch roughly 0.6 million sq miles (1.5 million sq km) and harbor a more mixed range of plants and animals, and a greater variety of scenery, from typical rolling plains to rocky gorges hiding secret, almost rainforestlike thickets.

The Wet and the Dry

The scattered trees that dot the savanna and clumps of sparse woodland are mostly eucalypts, or gums. "The Wet," or rainy season, is reliable, with evergreen trees and shrubs thriving where there are occasional floods and temporary lakes, and acacias grow in the drier south. During six to eight months of "the Dry," grasses shrivel to gray-brown and some trees shed leaves to curtail water loss.

This seasonality, along with generally poor soils, and Australia's distinctive wildlife due to its prehistoric isolation, mean that large native mammals, chiefly kangaroos, wallaroos, and wallabies, are relatively few in variety. Instead, most plant consumption and recycling is carried out by insects, especially termites. Their mounds, the tallest sometimes reaching 16 ft (5 m), dot the landscape in thousands, and their underground lifestyles and foraging for dead wood and plant matter allow them to survive the Dry. In addition, a rich variety of reptiles, such as the inimitable frilled lizard, and small marsupials, also live here.



COMPETING CATS

With so many smaller marsupial mammals in the tropical savannas, these are a rich hunting ground for introduced cats. In particular, feral cats compete with a native "marsupial cat," the northern quoll, whose numbers are declining.

NORTHERN QUOLL

More than

Temperatures often exceed 122°F (50°C)

POINTING NORTH
So-called "magnetic" termites build 7 ft (2 m) tall mounds, facing north-south—not to do with Earth's magnetic field, but to control temperature. The Sun's heat is side-on at dawn and dusk, and end-on at midday, so the mound stays cool.

LIFE AFTER FIRE

Like many local trees, the jarrah (a eucalypt tree) is adapted to occasional lightning-sparked fires—its underground part, or lignotuber, grows back. More frequent, extensive burns by livestock farmers threaten it and other vegetation species.

Six times the size of the UK

JARRAH